

Expansion and contraction in spatial case systems: divergence among Dargwa languages

One of the most remarkable features of East Caucasian (EC) languages is their rich inventory of spatial (a.k.a. locative) case forms (Kibrik 1970; Testelet 1980, 2003; Comrie 1999; Creissels 2009). These forms combine up to three morphemes which express location, direction and orientation (see table 1 on next page). Some languages of the family, such as Tabasaran, are cited (since Hjemlev 1935) as having some of the richest locative case systems worldwide.

This study focuses on the significant variation found in the locative case system across the Dargwa language group (DG, over 12 languages) of EC. While the core grammatical case system remains relatively stable, spatial case systems vary dramatically: From highly elaborate systems, among the richest in all EC languages (actually more than in Tabasaran), such as Tanti (Sumbatova & Lander 2014: 57) and Tsugni—both located in the central high mountain part of the Dargwa area—featuring over 80 spatial forms (and up to 174 when including variation of class markers, see Table 1), to radically simplified systems like those of the Kadar, Murego and Gubden languages, spoken in the peripheral lowland and foothill parts of the Dargwa zone, which have as few as five spatial cases (Mutalov 2019, see Table 2), i.e. one of the smallest inventories among EC languages .

How can we explain the coexistence of such divergent spatial case systems within the same language group, which exhibit both extensive expansion and radical reduction?

We think that these are the result of the interplay between topography and language contact.

1) Languages spoken in mountain areas tend to develop complex spatial case systems, viz. grammaticalized encoding of elevational or topographic information, detailed expression of spatial relations reflecting environmental demands (Urban, 2020: 10). Analogy seems to be one of the factors which were at play in the case of this expansion scenario. While spatial cases usually derive from the reanalysis and subsequent grammaticalization of earlier postpositional constructions, some of the attested forms were created by analogy with others (Alexeev 2003).

2) Languages whose speakers have migrated from the traditional highland areas of the Dargwa people — zones characterized by limited external linguistic contact — to lower areas, and have engaged in intensive bilingual contact with Kumyk (a Turkic language with just two locative spatial cases), show a marked reduction in the complexity of their spatial case systems. This reduction (or lack of development?) might result from language contact or diminished communicative needs for elaborate spatial distinctions in less topographically complex settings, or from both.

Additional support for the influence of language contact comes from Mehweb Dargwa (Dobrushina 2019:10). Due to ongoing contact with other EC languages that also have complex spatial systems (Avar and Lak), and continued residence in mountainous areas, Mehweb has not experienced significant system reduction with 25 locative forms (or 40 including variation of class markers). Conversely, Chirag Dargwa, although also spoken in mountainous areas but in the peripheral part of the Dargwa zone and in contact with Agul language (Lezgian group of EC), has a relatively reduced system of 10 locative case forms in total (Ganenkova 2016, see Table 3). As for Agul, it has about 24 spatial cases.

Table 1. Locative case system in Tsugni Dargwa

DIRECTION	ORIENTATION	LOCATION						
		APUD	ANTE	POST	SUB	SUPER	IN	INTER
LATIVE	-	-š:u	-sa	-gira	-gu	-ge	-le	-c:e
ESSIVE:CM	-	-š:u-CM	-sa-CM	-gira-CM	-gu-CM	-ge-CM	-le-CM	-c:e-CM
ELATIVE	DOWN	-š:u-r-ka	-sa-r-ka	-gira-r-ka	-gu-r-ka	-ge-r-ka	-le-r-ka	-c:e-r-ka
	UP	-š:u-r-ha	-sa-r-ha	-gira-r-ha	-gu-r-ha	-ge-r-ha	-le-r-ha	-c:e-r-ha
	HITHER	-š:u-r-ca	-sa-r-ca	-gira-r-ca	-gu-r-ca	-ge-r-ca	-le-r-ca	-c:e-r-ca
	THITHER	-š:u-r-de	-sa-r-de	-gira-r-de	-gu-r-de	-ge-r-de	-le-r-de	-c:e-r-de
DIRECTIVE:CM	DOWN	-š:u-CMa-ka	-sa-CMa-ka	-gira-CMa-ka	-gu-CMa-ka	-ge-CMa-ka	-le-CMa-ka	-c:e-CMa-ka
	UP	-š:u-CMa-ha	-sa-CMa-ha	-gira-CMa-ha	-gu-CMa-ha	-ge-CMa-ha	-le-CMa-ha	-c:e-CMa-ha
	HITHER	-š:u-CMa-ca	-sa-CMa-ca	-gira-CMa-ca	-gu-CMa-ca	-ge-CMa-ca	-le-CMa-ca	-c:e-CMa-ca
	THITHER	-š:u-CMa-de	-sa-CMa-de	-gira-CMa-de	-gu-CMa-de	-ge-CMa-de	-le-CMa-de	-c:e-CMa-de

Table 2. Locative case system in Kadar Dargwa

DIRECTION	LOCATION		
	APUD	SUPER	INTER
LATIVE	-ču	-ze	-ke
ESSIVE			
ELATIVE	-	-ze-ka	-ke-ka

Table 3. Locative case system in Chirag Dargwa

DIRECTION	LOCATION				
	APUD	ANTE	IN	INTER	POST
LATIVE	-š:u	-sa	-i/j	-c:e	-hra
ESSIVE					
ELATIVE	-š:u-rka	-sa-rka	-i-rka	-c:e-rka	-hra-rka

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